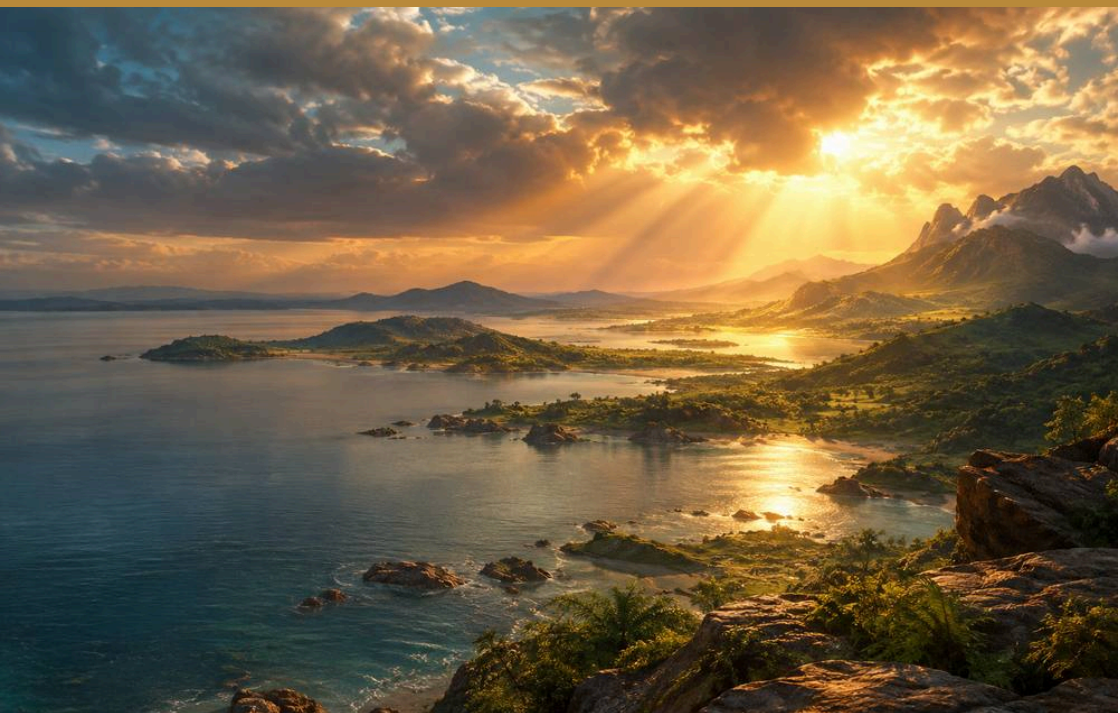
01

PART 1 OF 9

Beginnings

GEN 1–11

From the creation of the world to Abram's journey: the first chapters of the Bible set against the lands between Ararat and the Persian Gulf.



The World Where Everything Begins

Imagine opening a book whose first sentence embraces all of heaven and earth. That is how the Bible begins: with a story that has no map, cities, or borders yet, and still speaks from its first pages of order, goodness, and the relationship between humanity and God. We call chapters 1–11 of Genesis the primeval history. They are not a chronicle in the modern sense, but a grand introduction that answers the questions: where does everything come from, why is there suffering in the world, and where is humanity heading.

In this part of the atlas you will see that the story of beginnings only partly floats above the earth. Its second half has very concrete addresses: the mountains of Ararat on the Armenian highland, the plains of Shinar between the Tigris and the Euphrates, cities such as Babylon, Uruk, and Nineveh, and finally Ur of the Chaldeans and Haran. There archaeologists uncovered some of the oldest cities in the world, the first cuneiform writing, and monumental stepped towers called ziggurats. That is why the beginnings of the Bible can also be read with a map in hand.

It is worth remembering two layers of reading. The first is the message of faith that the Church and Christian tradition find in these texts: the world is good, humanity is called to relationship, and evil does not have the last word. The second is the cultural background of the ancient East, with its myths, laws, and cities. The reconstructions in this atlas are artistic interpreta-

tions based on excavations, not photographs. For places that cannot be pinpointed on a map, such as Eden, we honestly note that their location remains open.

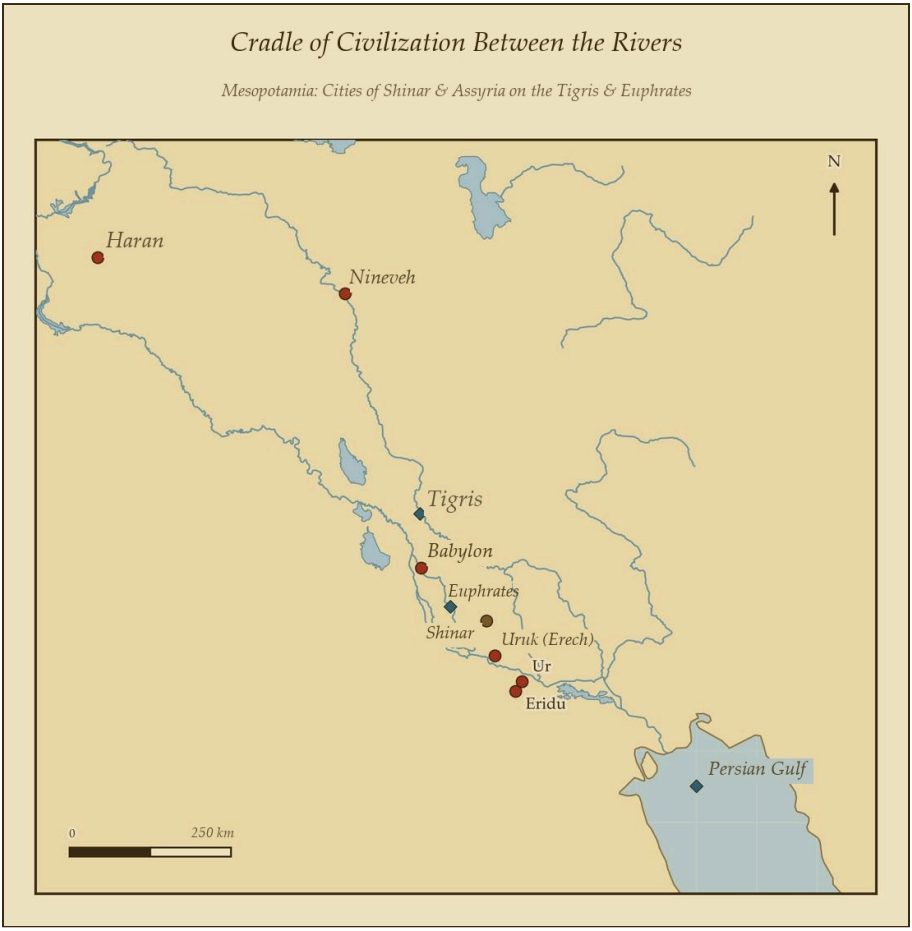
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HOW TO USE THIS ATLAS

Maps show routes and the locations of places; illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

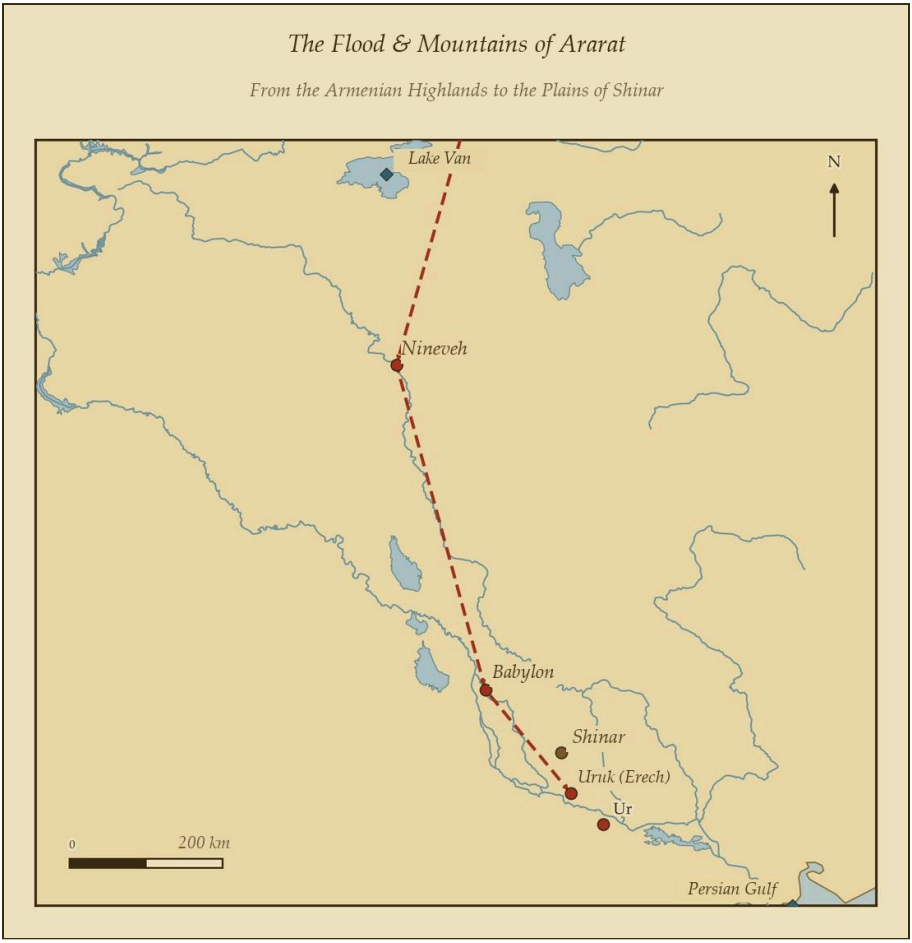
MAP 1.1



The dots mark cities and lands from the Book of Genesis, and the blue dots indicate rivers and the sea. Read the map from north to south: from Nineveh to Eridu on the ancient coast.

The map shows that Genesis tells of a real land between two rivers. All the cities named lie along the Tigris or the Euphrates, because water determined life and trade. The south, or Shinar, was a flat plain without stones, so people built with brick. The north, where Nineveh lies, was more mountainous. Notice that in ancient times the shoreline of the Persian Gulf reached farther inland, which explains why Eridu and Ur lay close to the sea.

MAP 1.2



The line shows the direction in which people came down from the highland to the plain, in keeping with the account of settling in Shinar. It is an approximate route along the Tigris and Euphrates, not an exact road.

Ararat lies on a high plateau from which waters flow down into Mesopotamia. That is why the story of the ark coming to rest in the mountains, followed by the settling of the plain, makes geographic sense. The extent of the region shows the difference in elevation: from over 5,000 m down to sea level. Note that the location of the peak where the ark rested is traditional, while the biblical text speaks generally of the mountains of Ararat, that is, the land of Urartu.

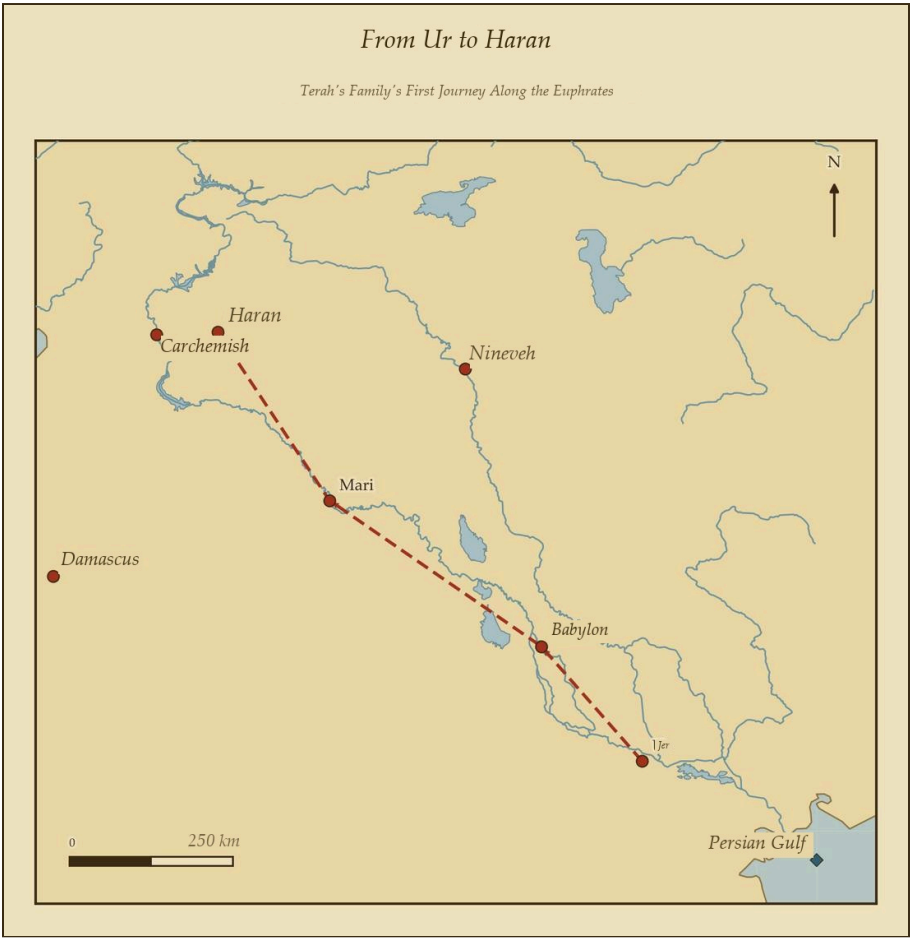
MAP 1.3



The dots are the centers and lands that Genesis links with the descendants of Noah. The map is simplified: the Table of Nations describes cultural connections, not exact borders.

Chapter 10 shows how the author pictured the surrounding world: from Greece in the west, through Egypt and the coast of Canaan, to Mesopotamia in the east. This arrangement is not a division by race, but a description of Israel's neighbors. The map shows that the center of this world was the basin of the eastern Mediterranean, and that Israel lay at the meeting point of great civilizations, which explains the later fate of the nation.

MAP 1.4



The line marks the likely route along the Euphrates, the most convenient for caravans. The Bible does not describe the details of the journey, so the course is approximate.

Caravans avoided the Syrian-Arabian desert and followed an arc along the Euphrates, where there was water and pasture. It is a longer but safer road than crossing the desert straight to Damascus. From Haran one could turn south toward Canaan, which is what Abram would do. The map shows that the decision to leave Ur was a journey stretched out over time, counted in weeks and months.

01 Creation of the World

GEN 1:1 – 2:4

Seven stages in which the world receives order, light, and life.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the world at the moment land emerges: broad waters, heavy light breaking through the clouds, and the first green slopes. It is not a specific landscape but a symbolic scene in which sky, sea, and earth are only just taking shape. You view it from high above, calm and free of people, to stress that the story begins with God's work, not with man.

The text that opens the Bible arranges creation in an orderly rhythm. God separates light from darkness, sets a vault of sky over the earth, gathers the waters, and lets the land appear. Then come plants, the heavenly bodies, fish, birds, and land animals. Finally humankind is created, male and female, in the image of God. The seventh day is a day of rest. The author does not describe physical processes, but teaches that the world is not the work of chance or of rival deities, but the good gift of one God. For the reader this has a practical dimension: the first chapter invites us to see everyday life as a gift, and work and rest as part of God's plan for humanity.

The geography in this account is cosmic rather than local, but it matters. The ancient Israelites lived among peoples who saw separate deities in the sun, the moon, and the sea. The biblical text simply calls them works of God: lamps in the sky and waters with boundaries set for them. For a farmer in Canaan, dependent on rainy and dry seasons, on the flooding of rivers and the rhythm of the year, this was a bold claim. The cycle of days and the week later became the basis of the calendar, and the Sabbath one of the most enduring customs of the community. It is also worth noting that Genesis took shape in a world full of competing stories, so its message of one Creator sounded clear and demanding.

FACTS

The text speaks of 6 days of creation and a seventh day, the day of rest.

02 Garden of Eden

GEN 2–3

A garden with four rivers, where humankind is called to work and to trust.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a lush garden beside a stream: fruit trees, tall grass, flowers, and soft morning light. Two figures are seen from afar, from behind, walking along a path between the trees. The colors are warm, and the vegetation recalls the oases of ancient Mesopotamia. The scene is an imagining, not a recreation of a specific place, since Eden has no known location.

The second account of creation takes us to a garden that God planted in the east. The man, formed from the earth, is given the task of tending and keeping this place. Animals appear, and then the woman, a companion equal to the man. The prohibition against eating from one tree becomes a test of trust. The serpent questions God's word, the humans reach for the fruit, and their relationships are broken: shame, excuses, and expulsion appear. At the same time, the text mentions God's care in preparing clothing for his creatures. This helps us understand why many generations read this text as a story of longing for peace, closeness with God, and a return to harmony among people.

The text lists four rivers flowing from a single source, among them the Tigris and the Euphrates. We know two of them well: they flow through present-day Iraq and mark out the land of Mesopotamia, the country between the rivers. The other two, the Pishon and the Gihon, cannot be clearly identified, which is why the location of Eden remains unknown. The story is probably a literary picture of life in an oasis, where water, the shade of trees, and cultivation are a gift. For desert peoples, a garden with rivers was a symbol of fullness, and exile from it a symbol of lost harmony. A reader familiar with the desert landscapes of the Near East will more easily grasp why the vision of a garden with flowing water meant the height of prosperity and security to the people of that age.

FACTS

The text names 4 rivers; the Tigris and Euphrates flow today through Iraq, and their lengths are about 1,900 and about 2,800 km.

03 Cain and Abel — the Land of Nod

GEN 4

A farmer and a shepherd, the first fratricide, and a wandering east of Eden.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a dry, open plain at dusk: a barley field on one side, a stony hill and a flock of sheep on the other. In the distance, two indistinct figures stand by a simple altar of stones, with smoke rising from it. The cloudy sky and long shadows give the scene tension without showing violence. The land of Nod remains undefined, so the background is generalized.

Cain works the soil, Abel tends sheep. Both bring offerings to God, but Abel's offering is accepted and Cain's is not. God warns Cain that sin is crouching at the door and must be mastered. Cain, however, invites his brother out to the field and kills him. Asked where Abel is, he answers with a question about whether he is his brother's keeper. Abel's blood cries out from the ground. Cain is condemned to wander, yet he receives a mark protecting him from vengeance. Thus begins a story of violence, but also of God's mercy. The whole event shows that evil grows by stages, from envy to deed, but God does not stop speaking with humankind even after its fall.

The account brings together two ways of life known from the Near East: settled farming and nomadic herding. Relations between them were often tense, because flocks damaged fields and crops reduced pasture. The land of Nod, where Cain departs, has a name linked to the Hebrew word for wandering, so it is probably symbolic and cannot be pointed out on a map. Later Cain founds a city, and his descendants develop herding, music, and metalworking, reflecting the birth of urban civilization. As a result, in Christian tradition the chapter became a call to responsibility for one's brother and to resistance against hatred.

FACTS

Cain is the first farmer and Abel the first shepherd in Genesis; Cain's lineage lists 7 generations.

04 Building Noah's Ark

GEN 6–8

Noah prepares the ark, and the flood changes the face of the known world.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows an enormous wooden vessel in a shipyard on a riverbank, surrounded by scaffolding and beams. Several figures in the distance carry planks, while dark clouds in the background foretell a storm. The vessel has a rectangular hull, not the boat shape familiar from children's illustrations. The image is an imagining based on the description of the dimensions, not evidence of a discovered structure.

Genesis describes a world full of violence and says that God regrets having made people. Noah, a righteous man, is told to build an ark of wood, coated with pitch, with three decks and one window. His family and pairs of animals enter it. Rain falls, the waters rise and cover the earth. After a time the ark comes to rest, Noah sends out birds, and on leaving the ark he offers a sacrifice of thanks. God makes a covenant and sets the rainbow as the sign of his promise. Noah's family is thus the beginning of a new humanity, and the rainbow reminds us that the covenant embraces all creatures and endures despite human weakness.

The flood story has neighbors in the literature of Mesopotamia, for example in the Babylonian Epic of Gilgamesh and in older Sumerian texts. This shows that the memory of a great flood was shared across the region. That should not surprise us: the Tigris and Euphrates overflowed and changed their beds, and the plains of southern Iraq were at times flooded. The biblical author, however, gives this tradition a different meaning: instead of capricious deities there is one God who judges evil and at the same time cares about rescue. The dimensions of the ark, given in cubits, come to about 150 meters in length. The mention of olive oil points to the mature agricultural culture of the world in which this story was told and written down.

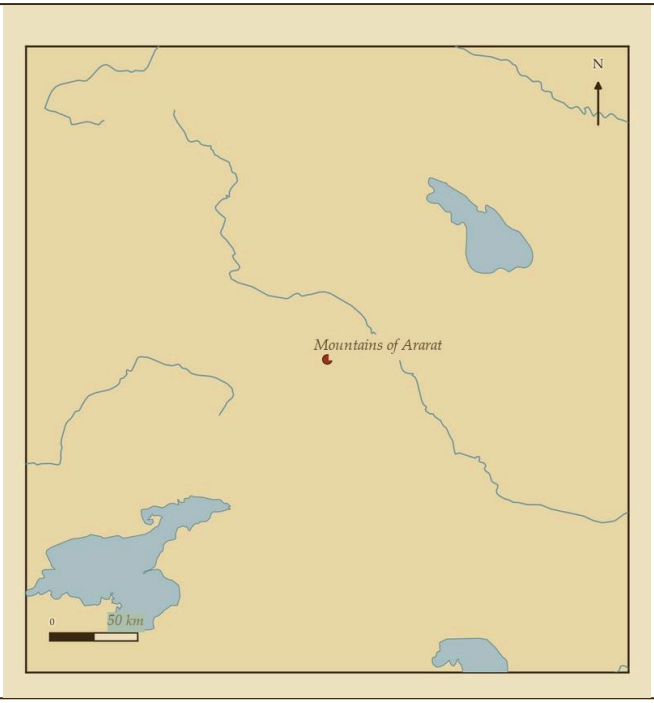
FACTS

Dimensions of the ark in the text: 300 cubits long, about 150 m, 50 cubits wide, and 30 cubits high.

05 Mountains of Ararat

GEN 8:4

The highland where, according to tradition, the ark came to rest as the waters receded.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: the place can be imagined as a stark volcanic massif: snow on the summits, rocky slopes, and cold, thin air. Below, valleys stretch out with fields and pastures. This is the present-day landscape, which lets us feel how remote and high this land must have seemed to the people of the Mesopotamian lowlands.

1.5 · MOUNTAINS OF ARARAT · GEN 8:4

When the floodwaters recede, the ark comes to rest on the mountains of Ararat. Noah waits, sends out a raven, and then a dove, which returns with an olive branch. After waiting again, the family leaves the ark and builds an altar. The text points not to a single peak but to a mountainous region. The Hebrew name Ararat corresponds to the Assyrian Urartu, a kingdom around Lake Van. Later, tradition attached the name to the tall, twin-peaked volcano Ararat, which today rises over eastern Turkey and can also be seen from Armenia. Today the area is nearly barren on the slopes and lush only in the valleys, which makes it easier to imagine that after the waters withdrew, people had to seek fertile land lower down.

Geographically this is the Armenian Highland, one of the highest areas of Western Asia. Both the Euphrates and the Tigris rise here, so waters flow from this place down into Mesopotamia. In the flood story this has symbolic meaning: the new world begins at the sources of the rivers, at a height from which the lowland can be seen. The road from Ararat to the plains of Shinar is about 800 km in a straight line. The location of the peak with the ark remains a matter of faith and tradition, not the result of scientific discoveries. For the reader it is a good example of how tradition and geography interweave into one story, without having to settle every detail.

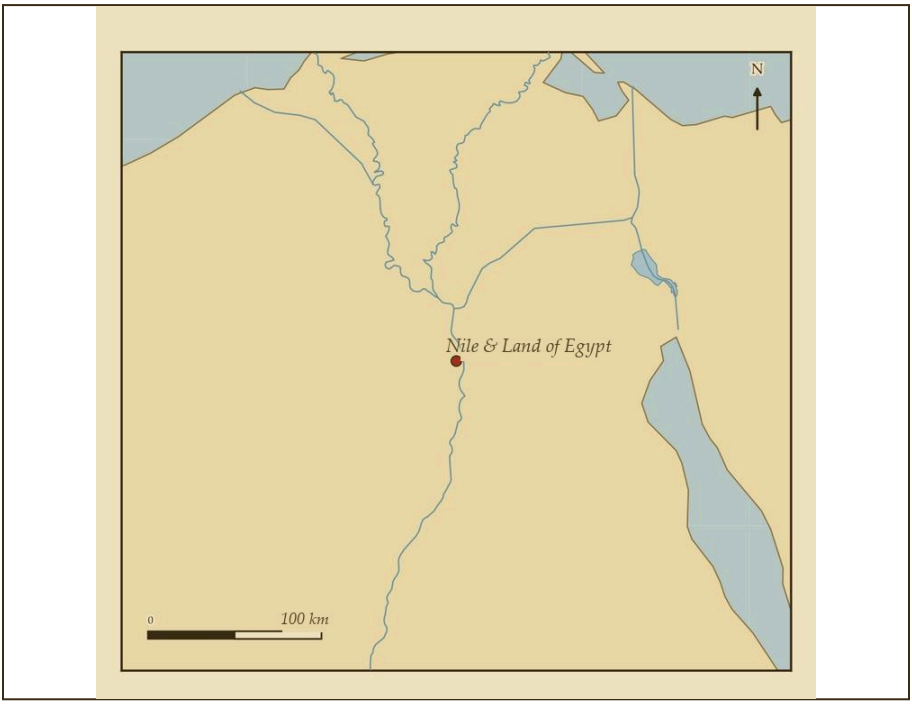
FACTS

The Ararat massif rises to about 5,137 m above sea level; the location is traditional.

06 The Nile and the Land of Mizraim

GEN 10:6–14

Egypt in the Table of Nations: the land of a great river and one of the first states in the world.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: imagine a broad river in a narrow strip of green. On both sides rise yellowish desert cliffs, and along the bank stand fields, palms, and low brick houses. Wooden boats with sails glide on the water. The contrast between green and sand helps us understand why the Nile was a gift to the Egyptians.

Chapter 10 of Genesis is the Table of Nations: a list of the peoples who spread out after the flood. The author arranges them by the families of Shem, Ham, and Japheth, not by today's ethnography but by the political and cultural ties of his own era. Among the descendants of Ham are Mizraim, that is Egypt, and peoples linked with the Mediterranean coast. The text shows that Israel lived among neighbors it knew from trade, wars, and travel, and regarded them as part of one human family. On this map you can see that Egypt and Mesopotamia were the two poles of the ancient world, linked by routes through Canaan, where the patriarchs would later arrive.

For Egypt the Nile was all-important, flowing from south to north through the desert and feeding a fertile valley only a dozen or so kilometers wide. The yearly flood deposited silt and made harvests possible, so Egypt was the granary of the region. The area around Memphis, where the valley meets the delta, was the site where the country was united around 3000 BC. The distance from Memphis to the Mediterranean is about 160 km, and from Memphis to Jerusalem the overland road is about 450 km, which explains the frequent contact between the two lands. That is why the Bible often portrays Egypt as a place of refuge from famine, and also as a place of testing for Israel.

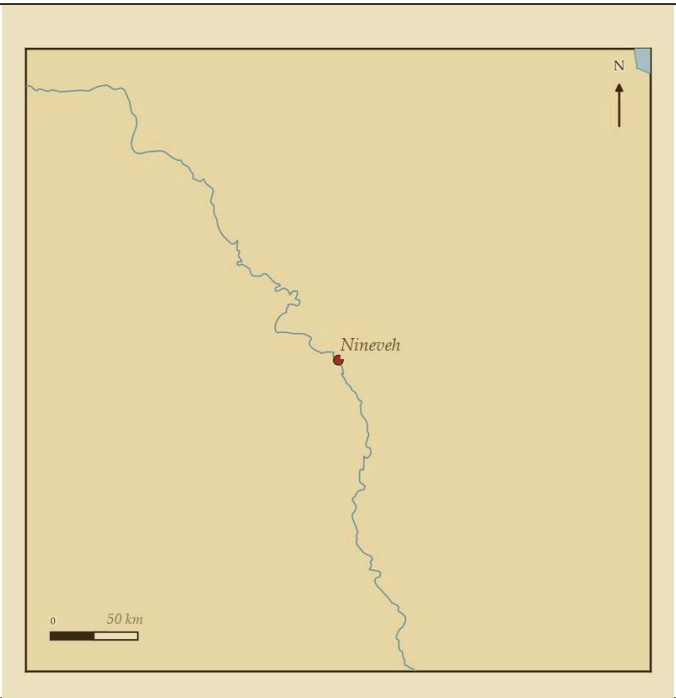
FACTS

The Nile is about 6,650 km long, and the valley in Egypt is often only about 10–20 km wide.

07 Nineveh

GEN 10:11–12

A city on the upper Tigris, later the capital of Assyria.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a mighty city with brick walls, great gates, and palaces on a hill. Before the gate, merchants bustle about with donkeys and carts. In the background the broad Tigris flows, and gardens give shade around the palaces. The whole is an imagining based on archaeological discoveries and Assyrian reliefs, not an exact picture of a single moment.

Genesis mentions Nineveh in connection with Nimrod, the legendary hunter and ruler, of whom it is said that he went out from the land of Shinar to Asshur and built cities there. Among them Nineveh is named. Later in the Bible the city will return: the prophet Jonah will be sent to call its people to repentance, and Nahum will foretell its fall. The Genesis text is thus a brief mention, but it sets a geographic direction: from the southern plains toward northern Assyria. Through the Book of Jonah, Nineveh also became a symbol of a city called to repentance, which gives this mention in Genesis added weight.

Nineveh lay on the eastern bank of the Tigris, where the river leaves the hill country and enters a flatter lowland. This position gave access to water, fertile land, and routes leading to Anatolia and Syria. Under Sennacherib, around 700 BC, the city became the capital of the empire, surrounded by walls many kilometers long. The library of Ashurbanipal, with thousands of clay tablets, was discovered there. The location of Nineveh is certain and confirmed by excavations on the mounds of Kuyunjik and Nebi Yunus. Today part of the ruins lies beside a large modern city, which makes the archaeologists' work harder, yet it still yields new discoveries.

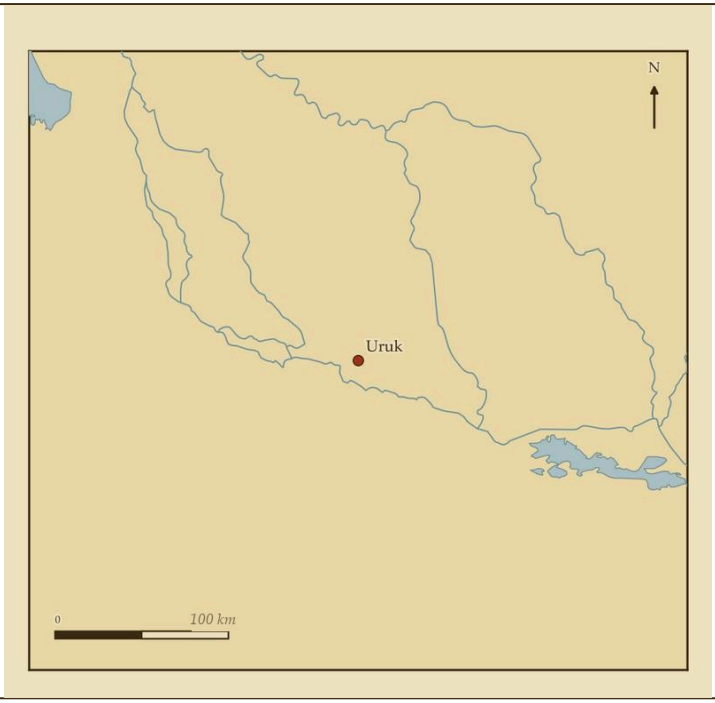
FACTS

According to research, the walls of Nineveh had a circumference of about 12 km; the city lies about 400 km from Babylon.

08 Uruk (Erech)

GEN 10:10

One of the first great cities of the world, the cradle of writing.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a densely built city of mud brick, with a high temple terrace above the rooftops. The streets are narrow, and green strips of gardens run beside the canals. In the distance reed boats glide by, and farmers lead donkeys carrying baskets of grain. Earth tones and the blue of the canals give the impression of a warm, dry climate.

Genesis says that the beginning of Nimrod's kingdom was Babel, Erech, Akkad, and Calneh in the land of Shinar. Erech is Uruk, a city with an extraordinary role in human history. Here around 3300 BC the first signs of writing appeared, at first used for economic records. Among the legendary rulers of Uruk is Gilgamesh, the hero of the famous epic. The biblical author mentions the cities of Shinar to show that people very early began to build states and conduct politics. Thanks to this information, Uruk is for us proof that the urban civilization of the Bible is no fairy tale, but the real backdrop of the story of the origins of states and power.

Uruk lay on an ancient course of the Euphrates, in southern Mesopotamia, which is low and fertile but lacks stone and timber. Its inhabitants built with clay brick and relied on a system of irrigation canals. The city may have had tens of thousands of inhabitants, and its walls, according to Sumerian tradition, were about 9 km long. Today the ruins, called Warka, lie in the desert because the Euphrates changed its course, which shows how much the life of cities depended on water. The Epic of Gilgamesh, tied to this city, shows at the same time how ancient people sought answers to questions about death and the meaning of life.

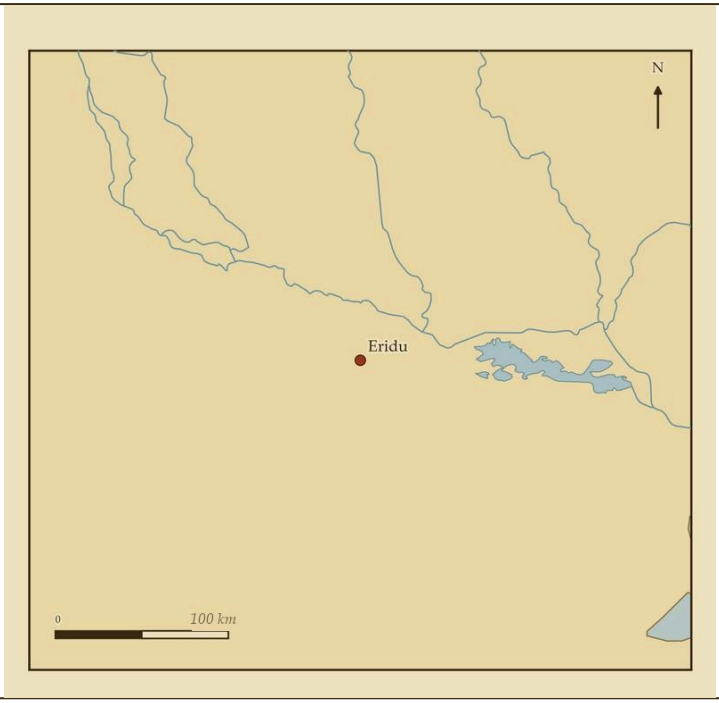
FACTS

According to research, Uruk covered about 5 km² and had about 40,000 inhabitants at its peak, around 3000 BC.

09 Eridu

GEN 10:10; 11:2

One of the oldest cities of Sumer, on the ancient lagoon of the Persian Gulf.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a small town at the edge of the marshes: houses of reed and brick, a small temple on a raised platform, and narrow boats gliding between the reed beds. In the morning mist hangs over the water, and nets dry on the shore. The image is an imagining based on discoveries at Abu Shahrain and on the landscape of the marshes of southern Iraq.

1.9 · ERIDU · GEN 10:10; 11:2

When Genesis describes the descendants of Noah, it says that people journeying from the east found a plain in the land of Shinar and settled there. Shinar is the biblical term for southern Mesopotamia, that is, Sumer and Akkad. One of the first centers there was Eridu, today the ruins of Abu Shahrain. The Sumerians regarded it as the city where settled life first began and where the temple of the god Enki was built. The biblical text does not name it, but it describes the environment in which such cities arose. This shift in the shoreline shows that the landscape described in the Bible was dynamic, and that rivers could create and transform whole regions within a few millennia.

Eridu then lay close to the shoreline of the Persian Gulf, among the marshes and lagoons that filled the mouth of the Euphrates. Today the shoreline is about 200 km farther south, because the rivers deposited enormous amounts of silt. The surroundings were fertile but lacked stone and timber, so the inhabitants traded with the mountains to the north and east. Archaeologists have found here the layers of a temple built successively over many centuries, beginning around 5000 BC. It is not certain whether the biblical author knew Eridu by name, but he undoubtedly knew the whole cultural world to which it belonged.

FACTS

The temple layers at Eridu go back to about 5000 BC, and the present ruins lie about 200 km from the sea.

10 Tower of Babel in Babylon

GEN 11:1–9

A city of brick and pitch, a tower reaching to heaven, and the scattering of languages.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

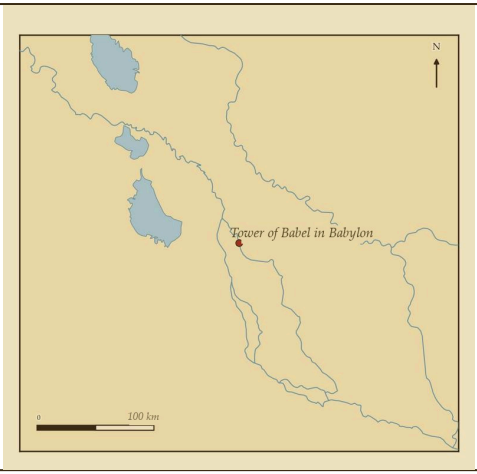
The artistic reconstruction shows an enormous stepped tower of brick rising above the city, with broad ramps and log scaffolding. At its foot is a crowd of workers, carts of bricks, and canals. The Euphrates flows along the edge. The whole is an interpretation based on excavations of ziggurats and descriptions in ancient sources, not a photograph of one particular structure.

The story says that all people had one language and the same words. Having come to the plain of Shinar, they decided to bake bricks, use pitch instead of mortar, and build a city with a tower reaching to heaven, to make a name for themselves and not be scattered over the earth. God comes down to see their work and confuses their speech. The building stops, and the city is named Babel. The text is a warning against the pride of a community that wants to replace God with its own work. Later the prophets and psalmists would refer to Babylon as a symbol of power hostile to God, but also as the place where the people of Israel would live in exile.

A wordplay in the text links the Hebrew word for confusion with the name Babel, that is, Babylon. The city lay on the Euphrates, about 85 km south of present-day Baghdad. The tower recalls the ziggurat Etemenanki, a stepped temple built in Babylon of baked bricks, using bitumen, the natural pitch from springs there. This was how the whole plain built: the lack of stone forced the use of brick. Thanks to this, the biblical author, knowing Babylonian realities, gave the story a distinct local color. For Christian readers, the story of the confusion of languages is completed by the event of Pentecost, in which people of different nations understand one message.

FACTS

Mesopotamian ziggurats usually had from 3 to 7 levels, and the ruins of Babylon lie about 85 km from Baghdad.


N
Tower of Babel in Babylon
0
100 km

11 Ur of the Chaldeans

GEN 11:27–31

Abram's hometown, on the Euphrates, with a great temple of the moon.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a city with a broad ziggurat on a mound, surrounded by compact brick buildings and date palms. A merchant with a donkey walks along a street, and in the background the sun shines over the Euphrates. The image is based on the excavations at Ur, including the preserved base of the ziggurat. The figures are small and seen from a distance, and the details of clothing are conjectural.

Chapter 11 moves from the story of peoples to the history of a single family. Terah, his sons Abram, Nahor, and Haran, and Abram's wife Sarai live in Ur of the Chaldeans. Haran dies in his native city, and Terah sets out with part of the family toward Canaan, but stops in Haran and dies there. For the reader this is an important moment: from the universal story of humankind, the Bible narrows down to one clan, from which the people of Israel will develop. This lets us see that Abram's call meant giving up a secure, prosperous life in one of the most advanced cities in the world.

Ur lay on the Euphrates in southern Mesopotamia and was one of the largest urban centers of its age. Excavations revealed the ziggurat of the moon god Nanna, rich royal tombs, and tablets with commercial records. Its inhabitants traded wool, grain, and metals with distant lands. According to the records, Ur flourished around 2100 BC, so the probable time of Abram corresponds to the period of the city's greatness. The very name of the Chaldeans appears later, which scholars explain as an updating of the name for the reader. This gives his journey a believable and human dimension: he was leaving a home that offered security, not ruins or a village.

FACTS

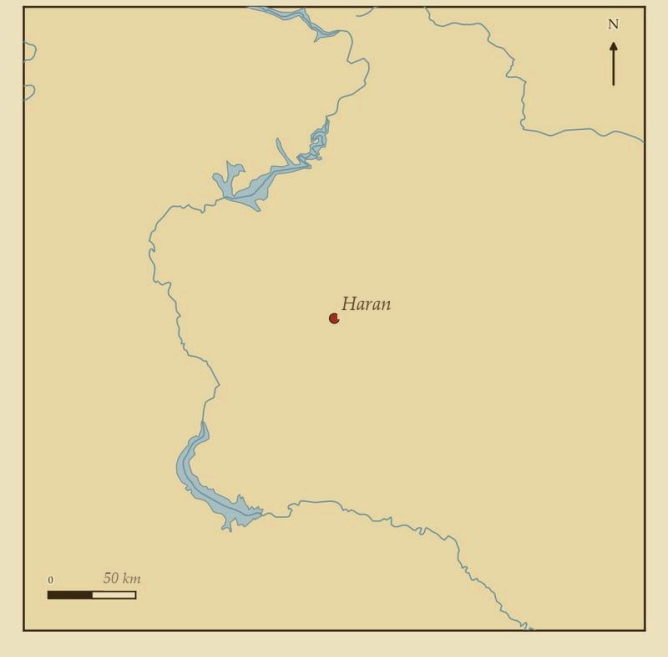
The ziggurat at Ur had a base of about 64 × 45 m, and the city lies about 300 km from the Persian Gulf along the ancient shoreline.


N
Ur of the Chaldeans
0
100 km

12 Haran

GEN 11:31–32; 12:4

A city on a trade route, where Terah's family stops.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: imagine an open plain with a walled city, a well, and a trail along which caravans with donkeys travel. The area is dry, but green along the river. Flocks graze around the city, and in the evening women draw water from the well.

1.12 · HARAN · GEN 11:31–32; 12:4

After leaving Ur, Terah's family reaches Haran and decides to stay there. Terah dies at the age of two hundred and five. In the next chapter God calls Abram to leave his country and his father's house, and promises him blessing and descendants. Abram, seventy-five years old, sets out with his wife Sarai, his nephew Lot, and his possessions. Haran thus becomes the last stop before the real journey to Canaan and the beginning of the story of the covenant. Israelite tradition remembered Haran as the home of Nahor's family and the place from which Isaac and Jacob would seek wives, which shows the lasting strength of family ties.

Haran lay on the Balikh River, a tributary of the Euphrates, in northern Mesopotamia. Trade routes linking Mesopotamia with Syria and Anatolia passed through the city, so it was an important caravan center. The distance from Ur to Haran is about 900 km in a straight line, and the journey along the Euphrates took many weeks. The city was also a center of worship of the moon god, like Ur. Today it lies near the Turkish-Syrian border, and in the area stand characteristic dome-shaped brick houses. In this way the city becomes a bridge between the primeval history at the beginning of the Bible and the history of the patriarchs, to which the next part of the atlas is devoted.

FACTS

The road from Ur to Haran is about 900 km in a straight line; Haran lies about 40 km from Şanlıurfa.

Questions for Reflection

1. Why does the author of Genesis describe creation in an orderly rhythm of days, and what does this orderly form say about trust in God as Creator?

2. How does knowing about Mesopotamia, its rivers, its brick, and its ziggurats change the way you read the stories of the flood and the Tower of Babel?

3. What does the move from the story of all humanity to the history of one family, that of Terah and Abram, mean for you?